

writer is to first understand the user whom he is writing for. Usually, the manual is directed towards a narrow and specific audience segment which needs to know more about a product. It is quite obvious from this that technical writing needs to be clear, accurate, easily understandable, and concise.

There are four stages you need to know before your technical writing career can blossom.

Stage one: How to become one

So how does an aspiring individual with a technical bent of mind and a good grasp over English language become a technical writer? What are the qualifications required? Factually speaking, there is nothing like a fixed basic qualification for a technical writer. Although companies may ask for a degree in science or a post graduate degree in English, what they are really looking for is an ability to understand and interpret



A technical writer compiles information of a technical nature and puts it in a language and format that can be easily understood by the readers who are unfamiliar with that technology

Sajitha Jayaprakash

Technical writer, Fluent India

technology, and explain that in the best and fewest words possible.

A potential technical writer needs just three things: fair amount of technical skills, an excellent command over the language, and a wide-ranging interest in technology. According to Jayaprakash, the most important qualifications of a technical writer are a “sound knowledge of language and the ability to grasp information”.

A good command over the English language means knowledge of grammar, an impressive vocabulary, the ability to maintain verbal consistency, structure and style, and so on. Of course, an abiding passion for reading always helps.

Sowmya N, another technical writer with Polaris software, Chennai, feels that the background is not important. “Whatever be the background, the output can be tuned to the desired fit as long you are technically *au fait* and have the willingness to admit ignorance where you lack”.

Technology is not bound by time. New technologies are emerging by the hour and the passion for technology will determine the time a technical writer spends in learning and under-

What do Technical Writers do?

Some of the major types of documentation done by technical writers are:

- User's manuals
- Online systems like Web sites and help files
- Multimedia development
- Reference manuals
- Documentation of product development and design

These are just some of the job functions that a technical writer may have to handle.

standing the latest technologies. A technical background would be helpful in this context.

“Successful writing on the job is not the product of inspiration, nor is it merely the spoken word converted to print. It is the result of knowing how to structure information in words and in visual design so that the writer achieves the intended purpose,” speaks Sowmya out of experience.

Good interviewing and interpersonal skills are attributes

which will take you a long way in the technical writing field. These skills are necessary because you will be required to interact with a lot of employees from small and medium enterprises (SMEs) such as programmers, engineers, managers, and the lot. It would be helpful if you have an awareness of logical development and assumptions, especially if you are planning to do documentation of software.

Stage two: What do they want?

You need to have a good working knowledge of the tools used for technical writing such as word processing, desktop publishing and online authoring applications. When it comes to word processors, there's nothing better than Microsoft Word. You would also be required to know how to use tables, styles as well as the illustrations in Microsoft Word. One of the most commonly used desktop publishing tools for technical writing is Adobe FrameMaker. You need to have a good working knowledge of online authoring applications for creating help systems. The most favoured online authoring applications are eHelp's RoboHelp and ForeFront's ForeHelp. Knowing one of these applications well will

Crossing over

Do you think your calling is technical writing rather than your current job? You might have a point there especially if you belong to one of the so-called 'related fields' of technical writing. Some of these fields are programming, teaching and journalism.

Programmers generally make good technical writers. This is mainly due to the fact that their background helps when it comes to understanding the technology involved, especially in writing technical manuals for software applications. Furthermore, technical writers with a programming background are able to get along better with other programmers in SMEs. They tend to view the programmer-turned-technical-writer as a part of the same gang.

A teacher fits the technical writer's profile well too. This profession has its own unique advantages when looked at from a technical writer's point of view. First of all, a teacher has the advantage of being a good communicator with excellent interpersonal skills. Secondly, he or she understands the subject well. These two factors help a teacher a great deal while trying to get a job in this field.

Another breed of professionals who can become good technical writers are journalists. They have already proven their writing skills and versatility with the language. All they need is a technical bent of mind.